appear earlier and grow more quickly. Organizations that recognize this shift will be positioned to respond intentionally. Those who do not will find that complexity overwhelms them.

19.8 ACME’s next move

ACME did not set out to build a strategic authorization capability. Instead, it evolved gradually, influenced by the needs of the systems they created and the relationships those systems fostered. By the time the organization recognized its significance, authorization had already become part of how ACME operated. That realization changed what came next.

For Alice and the engineering teams, authorization is no longer something to add after the fact. It is integrated into the design from the start. When new capabilities are proposed—whether a collaboration feature, a partner integration, or an agent-driven workflow—the conversation now includes how authority will be defined, delegated, and assessed. Shared policy infrastructure is not a barrier to innovation; it enables rapid iteration without introducing inconsistency.

Bob and other solution architects see the change in how systems fit together. Integration now avoids the need to reconcile incompatible access models or create custom logic for each partner. Access decisions are expressed in shared policy models that are shareable, adaptable, and understandable across services. As ACME’s ecosystem grows, authorization shifts from being a source of friction to a point of alignment.

For Carol and other leaders, the impact is visible in how teams work together. Boundaries that were once enforced through process and oversight can now be clearly defined in policy. Delegation is more precise. Responsibility becomes more transparent. Teams can move faster because they spend less time negotiating exceptions and more time building within clear limits.

Sam, the CISO, and the security team also see the system differently. Risk has not been completely eliminated, but it is now more visible and easier to manage. Authorization is no longer something that must be inferred from